Introduction and Definition of Terms

Overview of this Topic

Definition of the term sex, Definition of the term gender, Differences between gender and sex, Meaning of the term sexual orientation and the types, Definition of gender roles and the traditional gender roles.

The objectives

- ✓ To be able to define the term sex and gender
- ✓ To be able to differentiate gender from sex using appropriate examples
- ✓ To demonstrate knowledge on the types of sexual orientation
- ✓ To be able to define gender roles and use relevant examples of gender roles

Sex

Sex refers to the biological characteristics distinguishing male and female.

The definition above empasises male and female differences in terms of chromosomes, anatomy, hormones, reproductive systems and other physiological components.

(For instance, humans have the X and Y chromosomes. The females have XX and the males have XY. Men have the testosterone hormone that is dominant and the females' oestrogen. The sexual organs for males and females are also different (Penis and the vagina respectively). Then you alsofind that the physical structure of men and women is different.)

Sex in other terms refers to physical or physiological differences between males and females, including both primary sex characteristics (the reproductive system) and secondary characteristics (such as height and muscularity).

Gender

Gender refers to those social, cultural and psychological traits linked to males and females through particular social contexts

Gender is a term that refers to social or cultural distinctions associated with being male or female.

Gender refers to the socially constructed characteristics of women and men – such as norms, roles and relationships of and between groups of women and men.

"Gender," also refers to social or cultural distinctions associated with a given sex.

For instance, when babies are born, they are assigned a gender based on their biological sex—male babies are assigned as boys, female babies are assigned as girls, and intersex babies are usually relegated into one category or another.

N.B Scholars generally regard gender as a *social construct*, meaning that it does not exist naturally but is instead a concept that is created by cultural and societal norms. From birth, children are socialized to conform to certain gender roles based on their biological sex and the gender to which they are assigned.

A person's sex, as determined by his or her biology, does not always correspond with his or her gender. **Therefore, the terms *sex* and *gender* are not interchangeable.**
A baby boy who is born with male genitalia will be identified as male. As he grows, however, he may identify with the feminine aspects of his culture.

Since the term *sex* refers to biological or physical distinctions, characteristics of sex will not vary significantly between different human societies. For example, all persons of the female sex, in general, regardless of culture, will eventually menstruate and develop breasts that can lactate.

Characteristics of gender, on the other hand, may vary greatly between different societies. For example, in American culture, it is considered feminine (or a trait of the female gender) to wear a dress or skirt. However, in many Middle Eastern, Asian, and African cultures, dresses or skirts (often referred to as sarongs, robes, or gowns) can be considered masculine. The kilt worn by a Scottish male does not make him appear feminine in his culture.

Differences between Gender and Sex

- ✓ Gender is a *social construct,* meaning that it does not exist naturally but is instead a concept that is created by cultural and societal norms. The societies are the ones that determine the characteristics that are feminine and those that are masculine. Sex on the other hand is natural - determined after birth mostly by checking the child's genitalia. For example, if a child has a penis automatically it's a boy, if it's a vagina the baby is labeled a girl.
- ✓ Characteristics of sex do not vary significantly in different human societies while characteristics of gender may vary greatly between different societies. For example, in American culture, it is considered feminine (or a trait of the female gender) to wear a dress or skirt. However, in many Middle Eastern, Asian, and African cultures, dresses or skirts (often referred to as sarongs, robes, or gowns) can be considered masculine. The kilt worn by a Scottish male does not make him appear feminine in his culture.

- ✓ Sex makes us male or female; gender makes us masculine or feminine
- ✓ Sex is an ascribed status because a person is born with it, but gender is an achieved status because it must be learned
- ✓ The ascribed status of sex is less likely to be altered than the achieved status of gender. For example, all persons of the female sex, in general, regardless of culture, will eventually menstruate and develop breasts that can lactate. One can learn for instance to be masculine even if they were socialized to be feminine

Sexual Orientation

Sexual orientation refers to a person's emotional and sexual attraction to a particular sex (male or female).

Sexual orientation is typically divided into four categories:

- ✓ *Heterosexuality* **is** the attraction to individuals of the opposite sex
- ✓ *Homosexuality* **is** the attraction to individuals of one's own sex
- ✓ *Bisexuality* **is** the attraction to individuals of either sex
- ✓ *Asexuality* **is where there is no** attraction to either sex

Heterosexuals and homosexuals may also be referred informally as "straight" and "gay," respectively.

Gender Roles

The term **gender role** refers to society's concept of how men and women are expected to act and how they should behave. These roles are based on norms, or standards, created by society.
Gender roles are the expected attitudes and behavior a society associates with each sex – females and males.
As we grow, we learn how to behave from those around us. In this socialization process, children are introduced to certain roles that are typically linked to their biological sex.

Gender roles are cultural – they determine how males and females should think, speak, dress and interact within the context of society

Gender roles adopted during childhood normally continue into adulthood
Children then receive parental approval when they conform to gender expectations and adopt culturally accepted and conventional roles

In Canadian culture, **masculine roles** are usually associated with strength, aggression, and dominance, while **feminine roles** are usually associated with passivity, nurturing, and subordination.

Role learning starts with socialization at birth. Even today, our society is quick to outfit male infants in blue and girls in pink, even applying these colour-coded gender labels while a baby is in the womb.

One way children learn gender roles is through **play**. Parents typically supply boys with trucks, toy guns, and superhero paraphernalia, which are active toys that promote motor skills, aggression, and solitary play.

Girls are often given dolls and dress-up apparel that foster nurturing, social proximity, and role play. Studies have shown that children will most likely choose to play with "gender appropriate" toys (or same-gender toys) even when cross-gender toys are available because parents give children positive feedback (in the form of praise, involvement, and physical closeness) for gender-normative behaviour (Caldera, Huston, and O'Brien 1998).

The drive to adhere to masculine and feminine gender roles continues later in life. Men tend to outnumber women in professions such as law enforcement, the military, and politics. Women tend to outnumber men in care-related occupations such as child care, health care, and social work.

These occupational roles are examples of typical Canadian male and female behaviour, derived from our culture's traditions. Adherence to them demonstrates fulfillment of social expectations but not necessarily personal preference (Diamond 2002).

Gender roles shape individual behavior not only by dictating how people of each gender should behave, but also by giving rise to penalties for people who don't conform to the norms.

While it is somewhat acceptable for women to take on a narrow range of masculine characteristics without repercussions (such as dressing in traditionally male clothing), men are rarely able to take on more feminine characteristics (such as wearing skirts) without the risk of harassment or violence. This threat of punishment for stepping outside of gender norms is especially true for those who do not identify as male or female. Transgender, gender queer, and other gender-nonconforming people face discrimination, oppression, and violence for not adhering to society's traditional gender roles.

People who identify as gay, lesbian, bisexual, or queer are also ostracized for breaking the traditional gender norm of who a person of a given sex "should" be attracted to. Even people who identify as cisgender (identifying with the sex they were assigned at birth) and straight (attracted to the opposite sex) face repercussions if they step outside of their gender role in an obvious way.

Examples of Traditional Gender Roles

MEN	*WOMEN*
Should become Doctors	*Should become Nurses*

They are Bread winners	*Stay at home to take care of the children*
Play with trucks	*Play with dolls*
Play football, rugby, hockey	*Play netball, volleyball*
Good at Maths and sciences	*Good at English*
Dominant	*Submissive*

Summary

From the subtopics above, we have defined sex and also gender. We have also differentiated them and even used applicable examples. In addition, we have explained what sexual orientation means and the types that exist and lastly we have defined gender roles and even given examples of the traditional gender roles.